

when making payments to trusted merchants or when initiating transactions oneself.

How to protect yourself

Staying informed and cautious is the best defense against digital payment fraud. As online transactions become increasingly common, it is essential to adopt proactive measures to safeguard your financial information. Here are crucial steps to ensure secure transactions:

Never share UPI PINs or OTPs

UPI PINs and OTPs are meant for authentication and should never be shared with anyone, including supposed bank representatives or payment app support. No legitimate financial institution will ever ask for this information. If anyone requests these details, assume it is a scam.

Use official payment apps only

Always download UPI apps from verified sources such as Google Play Store or Apple App Store. Avoid using modified or unofficial versions, as they may contain malware designed to steal financial data. Keep apps updated to ensure security patches are applied regularly.

Enable app security features

Most UPI apps offer additional security measures such as biometric authentication, app locks, and two-factor authentication (2FA). Enabling these features adds an extra layer of protection against unauthorized transactions. Also, setting transaction limits on your UPI account can help mitigate potential losses in case of fraud.



Verify before scanning QR codes

Before scanning any QR code, ensure that it is from a trusted source. Check with merchants directly if you are unsure about

the authenticity of a payment QR code. Scammers can easily replace legitimate QR codes with fraudulent ones, so be cautious in public places.

Educate yourself and others

Spreading awareness about common scams and safe transaction practices can help prevent fraud. Educating family mem-



bers, especially the elderly and those less tech-savvy, is crucial. Many scams specifically target older individuals who may not be familiar with digital payment risks.

Use strong device security measures

Keep your mobile device secure with a strong password or biometric authentication. Avoid clicking on suspicious links received via SMS, email, or social media messages. Installing a reliable antivirus app can also provide additional protection against phishing attacks. Regularly check your device for unauthorized apps or settings changes.

Report fraud incidents to authorities

If you fall victim to a scam, report it immediately to:

- The National Cyber Crime Portal (<https://cybercrime.gov.in>)
- Your bank or payment service provider
- The RBI Ombudsman for Digital Transactions

Timely reporting can increase the chances of recovering lost funds and prevent fraudsters from targeting more victims. Many banks have a limited time window for reversing fraudulent transactions, so immediate action is critical.

Final thoughts

As digital transactions become the norm, so do the risks associated with them. Scammers constantly innovate new tactics, but users can protect themselves by staying vigilant and following best practices for secure online transactions. **d**